KELLY TELLS WHOLE STORY

Makes Complete Confession of How He Wielded the Ax in the Moore Home Five Years Ago

SAYS HE CRUSHED OUT LIVES OF EIGHT SLEEPING PEOPLE

While the Blood of His Listeners Runs Cold Kelly Dictates Details of Horrible Crime—Later Makes Complete Repudiation Through His Counsel

A complete and unqualified admission of having wielded the ax which crushed out the lives of Mr. and Mrs. J. B. Moore, their four children and the two Stillinger girls in this city on the morning of June 10, 1912, was made last Friday morning at the court house in Logan by Rev. Lynn Geo. J. Kelly, and will be used against him in his trial for murder at Red Oak.

To his horrified listeners Kelly told in detail how he grasped the handle of the ax and proceeded to slaughter, stating that a sermon, "Slay Utterly," caused him to kill. The preacher declared in his confession that a voice, which he believed to be that of God, led him and guided him in his terrible crime, the atrocity and mystery of which has kept this community in a turmoil of excitement for the past five years.

In detail the confession would cover more than a page of newspaper space. In it Kelly states that after the wholesale slaughter had been completed he was tired and remained in the Moore home to rest until just as day was breaking when he returned to the Rev. W. J. Ewing home and sought his bed.

After making the confession it is stated that Kelly said: "My soul is relieved for the first time in five years. Never let me run loose again—I'll do the same thing over again."

Kelly, in reality, made two confessions. The first was made between midnight Thursday and daybreak Friday in the presence of Attorney General H. M. Havner, Attorney J. J. Hess of Council Bluffs, Sheriff M. D. Meyers of Logan, his deputy, Charlie Atkins, and J. E. Risden, a state agent. The other confession was made after this group had left Kelly. It was made in the presence of Sheriff Meyers, Deputy Sheriff Atkins, State Agent Risden and Paul Roadifer, county attorney of Harrison county. Kelly dictated his secod confession to Mr. Roadifer, who wrote it on a typewriter as it fell from the preacher's lips. He then signed and swore to the statement in the presence of the clerk of the district court of Harrison county.

However, later in the day Friday, J. A. McKenzie of the legal firm representing Kelly, went to Logan and visited the preacher in his cell. McKenzie then said Kelly completely repudiated the confession. Judge A. L. Sutton of Omaha, of Kelly's counsel, says the confession is not worth the paper it is written on. Drastic third degree methods were used by state authorities to get the signed statement from Kelly, Judge Sutton declares. On the other hand, those present when the confession was secured, absolutely deny using any force of coercion on the preacher.

Kelly is said to have been wanting to make a statement for several weeks. Friday, notice was served on the preacher of a large number of witnesses who would testify against him at the coming trial at Red Oak. Friday evening he told Sheriff Meyers and State Agent Risden that he committed the murders. Attorney General Havner was in Magnolia that day, speaking at the old settlers' picnic. Kelly knew Havner was in the vicinity.

"I done it," Kelly said to Sheriff Meyers and Mr. Risden. "I want to see the attorney general." Attorney General Havner said he was willing to listen to anything Kelly had to say.

The preacher was taken from his cell over to the sheriff's office in the court house. When Kelly told the officials he wanted to make a confession, Mr. Havner immediately sent for Attorney J. J. Hess of Council Bluffs, who has been retained to assist in the prosecution of the trial against Kelly. Mr. Hess immediately left for Logan, taking with him J. J. Ferguson, a court reporter. Mr. Hess and Mr. Ferguson arrived in Logan sometime during the night.

Paul Roadifer, the county attorney who listened to the preacher's story, states that it was entirely voluntary and that Kelly's reason for making the confession, the latter said, was to clear the name of Former Senator F. F. Jones, against whom charges have been made in connection with the case.

"When Kelly started to talk," said Mr. Hess, who heard the whole confession fall from the lips of the preacher, "there was no stopping him. He told the gruesome story from beginning to end. There is no chance of a mistake."

Kelly's Story

Kelly said he went to Villisca on Saturday evening, June 8. On Sunday he filled two pulpits near Villisca, returning to Villisca late in the afternoon. He took supper at the home of Rev. W. J. Ewing, pastor of the Presbyterian church. After supper, Kelly says, he accompanied the Ewing family to church and then returned home with them after the services.

With Rev. Mr. Ewing, Kelly says he sat and talked until about 11:30 o'clock when the family retired for the night. The Ewings were sleeping in a tent out of doors. After Mr. Ewing had shown him to his room upstairs in the house, Kelly said he went to bed but couldn't sleep.

A sermon upon which he had been working kept him awake. He had heard the famous Gypsy Smith preach upon the text "Slay Utterly" and he was cogitating and going over in his own mind, a sermon of his own on the same subject. His mind would not rest. His thoughts were constantly on the text "Slay Utterly." In his own mind he was elaborating upon the ideas which he had heard expressed by the famous evangelist.

Heard Strange Voice

Suddenly from out of the night stillness, Kelly said he heard a sound, like that of a windmill. Restless and unable to sleep, Kelly says he arose and walked about the room, finally going out onto a little balcony. Out in the open, he could hear no noise, he said. He then turned back into his room and went back to bed. But still sleep wouldn't come. Finally, he determined to take a walk. This was about 12:45 o'clock, Kelly recalled. Still turning over in his mind, the thoughts of the text "Slay Utterly," Kelly says he walked over towards the Presbyterian church. In the midst of his pondering he says he heard a voice which bade him "go farther." He says his path then led him down toward the end of the street on which the Joe Moore home is located. Approaching the Moore house, Kelly says he saw a shadow. Something prompted him to follow it and he says he saw an ax. He picked it up. Then came a voice which rang in his ears, "Go in, slay utterly."

Followed the Shadow

He followed the shadow around to the front of the house where it rested at the front door. He entered the house and went up stairs. Kelly says as he mounted the stairs, the thought came through his mind that he was ascending on Jacob's ladder.

Arriving at the top of the stairs, Kelly says he turned into the room where four children were sleeping. He paused. Then came the voice again which Kelly says was that of God. "Slay utterly," it commanded. "Suffer little children to come unto me."

Kelly says he answered this with the muttering, "Yes Lord, they're coming now," or "Yes Lord, they're coming quick," he wasn't sure which expression he used. Then while the blood of his listeners almost ran cold, Kelly told how he grasped the handle of the ax and proceeded to slaughter.

Killed Children First

At this point of the story, Attorney Hess asked Kelly if he was sure he killed the children first. Kelly responded, "Yes, I know I did, children have bothered me all my life. I'm sure I killed them first."

From the children's room, Kelly says he went into the room where Mr. and Mrs. Moore were sleeping. Here the voice again prompted him. "More work yet. There must be sacrifices of blood." Kelly says he told God he was working as fast as he could.

Killed Mrs. Moore First

"I killed the parents," Kelly said, "I think I killed the mother first."

Kelly says he then felt tired and went down stairs searching for a place to lie down. He went into a room and discovered two girls. "More work still," was the voice that spoke to him then. "I still held the impulse of 'slay utterly'" Kelly declared in telling of the murdering of the two little girls that he found in this room.

Kelly remained in the Moore house until just as day was breaking in the east, he says, and then returned to the Ewing home and again sought his bed. He was still unable to sleep. Packing his suit case, he slipped out of the house and caught the train which leaves Villisca for the west at 5:19 a. m., and then returned to Macedonia where he made his home.

After completing the story of how he committed this most gruesome crime, Kelly went on to say that ever since that awful night the text "Slay utterly" had been ever in his mind. It constantly tormented him. "Never let me run loose again. I'll do the same thing over," he pleaded with the little group that heard him relate his terrible crime. As he finished his tale, Kelly seemed relieved. "My soul is relieved for the first time in five years," he remarked.

Not Urged to Confess

Attorney Hess and Mr. Risden were both emphatic in their denials that any sweating or "third degree" methods had been used on Kelly to get him to make a confession. On the contrary, they say, Kelly talked voluntarily, and remained perfectly calm and cool all the while he was telling the circumstances of the night of June 9, 1912, when he turned the happy home of Joe Moore into a house of carnage.

"There was no urging in any form," Mr. Hess declared, "and Kelly knew all the time that everything he was saying was being taken down and would be used against him in court."

As to the story that Kelly was told that a mob was forming at Red Oak, prepared to lynch him, and that his signed confession would secure for him the protection of state troops, Mr. Risden said nothing of the kind was ever said. Risden did say that Kelly himself asked not to be taken back to Red Oak. "For God's sake, don't take me back to Red Oak, they'll kill me," Kelly exclaimed as he finished his statement.

After Kelly had finished his first story, he was taken back to his cell. About 7 o'clock, Sheriff Meyers and Mr. Risden went in to see him. Mr. Risden pointed out to the preacher how the whole state of Iowa was interested in the Villisca case and that if there was anything further he wanted to say he could do so, and say it in his own way. Mr. Risden says this opportunity was welcomed by Kelly and he was taken back to the court house where he dictated to County Attorney Paul Roadifer who sat at a typewriter and wrote Kelly's own words. This statement was then signed and sworn to by Kelly.

Kelly Repudiates Confession

On Friday afternoon John J. McKenzie, of Sutton & McKenzie, Omaha, and J. C. Pryor, of Tinley, Mitchell, Pryor & Ross, Council Bluffs, went to see Kelly. They were with him during the afternoon, and at this time, McKenzie says, the preacher repudiated his confession.

Upon returning to Omaha McKenzie said that according to his client the "third degree" had been given him, that Attorney General Havner and six deputies had grilled him all Thursday night, until 4 o'clock Friday morning, when he broke down and confessed. According to McKenzie, Kelly said he was told a mob of Montgomery county citizens were awaiting him at Red Oak and would hang him if he did not confess. He was told, according to the story, that the state had 20,000 soldiers at Des Moines and he would be given ample protection if he would but confess. He begged for his attorney, according to his lawyer, but was told that "It won't do you any good anyhow." Furthermore, according to the preacher's story to his attorney, the attorney general and his deputies outlined the course that would be taken if he would make the admission. He would be sent to an insane asylum for six months, then freed.

Meyers' Strong Statement

This and the report that rough "third degree" methods had been employed were flatly denied by Sheriff M. D. Meyers Saturday morning. He said that anyone who says that any third degree methods were used on Reverend Kelly, that he was refused his attorney, that he was coaxed, forced, or influenced in any way to make his confession; that he was promised freedom after six months in an asylum, that he was told that a mob was awaiting him or that he was treated in any way other than considerate and careful—that anyone who makes such a statement is a liar.

This statement of the sheriff was approved by Charlie Atkins who was present during the time that the alleged sweating is said to have been done.

Sheriff Meyers said that on Friday night Sheriff Robert Dunn drove to Logan from Red Oak to serve further notice of evidence on Kelly and that during the time, Kelly with Mrs. Kelly, said he wanted to call Attorney Sutton, one of his counsel. Meyers told them that they could call at any time they wanted to.

Mitchell's View

W. E. Mitchell, of Council Bluffs, one of the preacher's attorneys, dismissed Kelly's confession with a wave of his hand. "Why that man labored with me and tried to convince me that he sunk the Lusitania," Mr. Mitchell said. Mr. Mitchell says Kelly's confession is due to a state of mind which he has worked himself into and that when the proper time comes, the matter will be all cleared up.

Sutton's Opinion

Judge A. L. Sutton, of Omaha, of Kelly's counsel, says: "The so called confession which Attorney General Havner claims to have been made by Rev. Mr. Kelly, was secured by intimidation and has been repudiated by my client. He was grilled from 8 p. m. to 4 a. m.

"Accompanied by the sheriff, deputies and state agents, Havner invaded Rev. Kelly's cell in Logan, Iowa, jail. The prisoner had been sick for several days, had refused food and was brooding over his troubles. Havner personally grilled Rev. Mr. Kelly, who tells me the attorney general said:

"'A mob is forming in Red Oak and they are going to hang you. Ninety per cent of the people of Montgomery county are included. If you will make a confession, I will have 20,000 soldiers there to protect you. We will send you to an insane asylum for six months and then let you go free.'

"Frightened because of the lynching statements made by the attorney general, and anxious to secure protection from violence, Rev. Mr. Kelly made an alleged confession, believing it his only salvation. As soon as I saw my client he promptly repudiated the entire confesison. I do not know what the statement contains. I understand Haver has it.

"The testimony of 85 witnesses was read to the prisoner in an attempt to break him down. My client asked for an opportunity to consult me before he talked but Havner refused him that privilege. After Havner had grilled him, he departed and his agents took the signed statement.

"Rev. Mr. Kelly is absolutely innocent of complicity in the Villisca ax murders. The trial will go forward Sept. 4, as scheduled."

Havner's Statement

The confession signed and sworn to by the Rev. Lynn G. J. Kelly, but later repudiated, was entirely voluntary upon his part, and was obtained by the most pacific means, Attorney General H. M. Havner declared in an authorized statement, issued at Des Moines Saturday night. He said:

"I went to Harrison county last Thursday particularly to make a speaking engagement at Magnolia. I took with me a statement of additional evidence gathered in the Kelly ca and which, by law, we are required serve upon the defendant in adva of the trial.

"This statement of evidence read to Mr. Kelly by Sheriff Mey of Harrison county shortly after o'clock in the evening I was not pr ent and had not planed to see Ke before catching my train to Cou Bluffs.

"Before the sheriff completed re ing the statement, Kelly stopped h declaring that he was guilty of murder and was ready to make statement.

"He told the sheriff that he want to see me, and Meyers told him t there was no use talking to me unl he was ready to make a clean bre of the whole affair.

"Kelly then said that he wished confess, and Meyers sent word to not to take my train.

"Kelly was then brought to court house, and in the presence o number of witnesses made a detail statement of the crime. J. J. Hess, attorney from Council Bluffs, Sher Meyers, J. J. Risden and two oth persons, both residents of Log whose names I do not know, we present, as well as two court report whom we called in

"So far as there being any intim dation is concerned, Kelly was anxio to make the statement, and talked length upon the crime. He was formed by myself and others pres anything he said would be u against him, and that he need exp no reward in the way of clemency otherwise.

"He was told this at least twe times during the night. He began make his statement at about 12 o'clock and finished it about 3:30.

"Three or four hours after he returned to the jail he again cal for the sheriff, this being shortly ter 7 o'clock Friday morning. I left the city and was in Cou Bluffs. Kelly told the sheriff that desired to dictate an account of crime. This he did in the presence the sheriff, county attorney and cl of the court, making his statem while it was written down directly on a typewriter.

"This statement he read over, ad ed, and swore to entirely of his o free will, and without the slight pressure being used.

"I never spoke a word to Rev. Kelly in the Logan, Iowa, jail in whole life. I had been absent fr town three hours before the sig statement was made. There is not word of truth in Judge Sutton's sta ment.

"Rev. Mr. Kelly went from his c to the court house at his own quest, personally dictated the co fession in the presence of the sher the county attorney and the court porter, and swore to it before t

THE DEVOTED FATHER AND MOTHER



J. B. MOORE, age 43



MRS. J B. MOORE, age 39

THE FOUR BRIGHT CHILDREN OF MR. AND MRS. J. B. MOORE



HERMAN MOORE, age 11



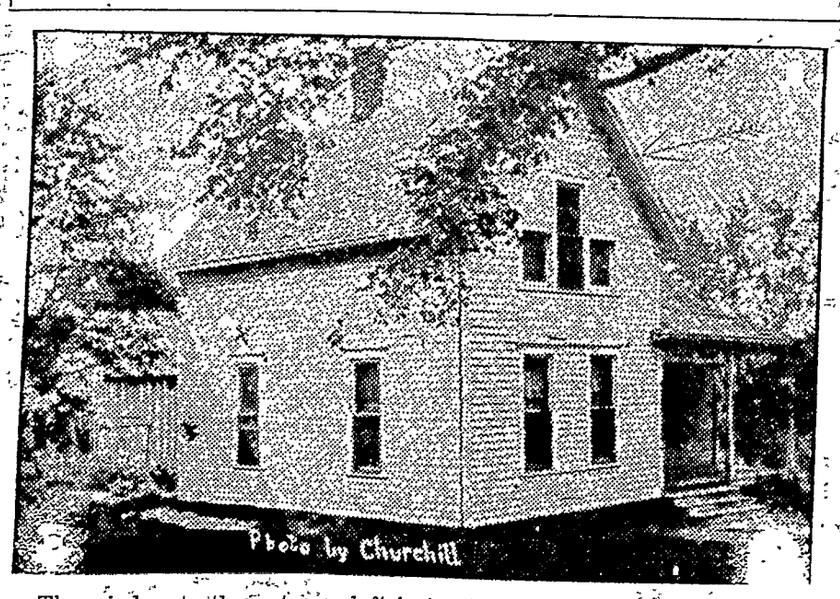
BOYD MOORE, age 7

PAUL MOORE, age 5



KATHERINE MOORE, age 10

HOME WHERE CRIME WAS COMMITTED



The window to the extreme left is in the room which was occupied by the two Stillinger girls. The three windows upstairs are in the room where the four Moore children were sleeping. Mr. and Mrs. Moore occupied the back room on the second floor, into which the stairway opens.

FUNERAL IN THE CITY PARK--



Probably seven thousand people attended the funeral services for J. B. Moore and family and the Misses Lena and Ina Stillinger at Villisca on Wednesday afternoon, June 12, 1912, and on every face in that great assembly was plainly depicted the deep sorrow the community felt. The picture was taken from the north side of the square looking south.